

The Rosés of Puglia

What to drink — and why — in Italy's great rosato region

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We got back from Puglia yesterday, and before I lose the thread, I want to write down what I learned about the wine — specifically the rosé, which turned out to be the story of the whole trip.

I knew Puglia had rosé. I didn't know it had *this much rosé*, or that it had been doing serious rosé before Provence made it fashionable. The famous Five Roses from Leone de Castris, bottled in 1943, is often cited as Italy's first commercially important rosato. That's not a quirky footnote — it tells you something about how deeply rosé is woven into the region's wine culture.

Here's what I found worth knowing.

The Grapes

Grape	Where in Puglia	Rosé Color	Typical Flavors	Structure
Negroamaro	Salento, Lecce, Brindisi	Deep salmon to cherry pink	Cherry, raspberry, pomegranate, herbs	Medium-bodied, savory
Primitivo	Manduria, Gioia del Colle	Bright pink	Strawberry, watermelon, spice	Fuller, richer
Susumaniello	Brindisi	Pale to medium pink	Red currant, citrus, rose petals	Fresh, elegant
Bombino Nero	Castel del Monte	Pale salmon	Strawberry, peach, flowers	Light and delicate
Nero di Troia	Northern Puglia	Medium pink	Cranberry, wild berries, herbs	Structured, mineral
Malvasia Nera	Throughout Salento	Usually blended	Plum, violets	Softens blends

Negroamaro — The One You’ll See Everywhere

This is the signature grape for Puglian rosé, and the name is a little misleading — “black and bitter” — because the rosés are vibrant and food-friendly, not harsh. What you get:

- Cherry and raspberry fruit
- Mediterranean herbs
- A slight savory bitterness on the finish
- Enough body to actually pair with food

Think Provence rosé with more personality. It’s great with seafood pasta, burrata, grilled octopus, pizza — basically everything you’re going to eat in Puglia.

Look for: Five Roses (Leone de Castris), Salice Salentino Rosato DOC.

Primitivo — Rich and Fruity

Primitivo is genetically almost identical to Zinfandel, which I didn’t know going in. In rosé form it becomes much fresher than you’d expect — strawberry, watermelon, red cherry, white pepper, with a fuller mouthfeel and slightly higher alcohol than a typical Provence pour.

Think: White Zinfandel’s sophisticated Italian cousin. Works well with charcuterie, grilled pork, tomato dishes. Wines from Manduria tend to be bigger than those from Gioia del Colle.

Susumaniello — The One Worth Seeking Out

Nearly extinct not long ago, Susumaniello is now one of Puglia's most exciting grapes. The rosé is pale to medium pink and tastes like red currants, pink grapefruit, rose petals, and a salty sea-breeze minerality. Less heavy than Primitivo, more elegant than Negroamaro.

Think: somewhere between Provence and Etna rosé. Fantastic with shellfish, raw tuna, shrimp risotto.

Look for: Tenute Rubino Susumaniello Rosato.

Bombino Nero — Light and Floral

The grape of the Castel del Monte Rosato DOC. Bombino Nero gives color quickly without excessive tannin, which makes it ideal for pale, delicate rosés — wild strawberry, peach, white flowers, citrus. Light body, crisp acidity. Think Italian rosé with a touch of Pinot Noir character.

Look for: Rivera Pungirosa.

Nero di Troia — The Structured One

Common in northern Puglia. Cranberry, red cherry, herbal notes, mineral finish. These rosés can actually age, and they have more tannic structure than anything else in the category. Think rosé with some of the seriousness of a red wine.

The Regional Styles

Style	Grape	Character
Salento	Negroamaro	Darker pink, savory, best with meals
Manduria	Primitivo	Rich, fruity, higher alcohol
Brindisi	Susumaniello	Fresh and elegant
Castel del Monte	Bombino Nero	Pale, refined

Bottles Worth Seeking Out

Easier to find:

- Leone de Castris Five Roses — the Negroamaro blend that started it all

More serious:

- Cantele Negroamaro Rosato
- Tormaresca Calafuria
- Tenute Rubino Susumaniello Rosato
- Rivera Pungiroso (Bombino Nero)
- Varvaglione 12 e Mezzo Rosato

Puglia vs. Provence

One thing that kept coming up: Puglian rosato isn't really an aperitif wine. Compared to Provence:

	Provence	Puglia
Color	Pale	Often deeper pink
Fruit	Delicate	Riper
Body	Very light	More texture
Character	Mineral	Savory and herbal
Role	Poolside sipper	Built for food

Puglia's rosé is less about looking good on a terrace and more about sitting down to a meal — which suits the food perfectly. It might be one of Italy's most underrated wine styles, and I say that having now drunk a fair amount of it at lunch.